```
    }
}
```

❶ The action is executed with a request to GET /api/cars.

❷ The API model containing the data is an IEnumerable<string>.

❸ This data would normally be fetched from the application model.

You saw in section 20.2 that it's possible to return data directly from an action method, in which case the middleware formats it and returns the formatted data to the caller. But how does the middleware know which format to use? After all, you could serialize it as JSON, as XML, or even with a simple `ToString()` call.

WARNING Remember that in this chapter I'm talking only about web API controller responses. Minimal APIs support only automatic serialization to JSON, nothing else.

The process of determining the format of data to send to clients is known generally as *content negotiation* (conneg). At a high level, the client sends a header indicating the types of content it can understand—the `Accept` header—and the server picks one of these, formats the response, and sends a `Content-Type` header in the response, indicating which type it chose.

The `Accept` and `Content-Type` headers

The `Accept` header is sent by a client as part of a request to indicate the type of content that the client can handle. It consists of a number of MIME types, with optional weightings (from 0 to 1) to indicate which type would be preferred. For example, the `application/json,text/xml;q=0.9,text/plain;q=0.6` header indicates that the client can accept JSON, XML, and plain text, with weightings of 1.0, 0.9, and 0.6, respectively. JSON has a weighting of 1.0, as no explicit weighting was provided. The weightings can be used during content negotiation to choose an optimal representation for both parties.